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INTERVIEW

Small step, giant leap

Sarpreet Singh is poised to become the **first player** of Indian origin to compete at the FIFA World Cup since the 2006 edition.



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As a football-loving kid growing up in New Zealand, one of Sarpreet Singh's foundational memories of the sport is from when he was a 10-year-old. He's watching from the stands of Wellington's Westpac Stadium as New Zealand beat Bahrain 1-0 to qualify for the 2010 FIFA World Cup.

"My mother took me and my brother to Wellington for the game. I'd brought posters of the players and managed to get them signed as they came past us," he recalls. "It was a great tournament. I remember we only played the three group games but we were unbeaten in all of them. So I do remember those memories fondly," he says.

Sixteen years later, Sarpreet **(above, in white)**, now 26, is part of a New Zealand team that has qualified for the 2026 World Cup. On

March 24, the midfielder was part of the squad that beat New Caledonia 3-0 in the final of the Oceania section of the 2026 FIFA World Cup qualifiers played at Auckland's Eden Park.

The momentousness of the occasion isn't lost on Sarpreet. New Zealand will be competing at a World Cup for the first time since 2010 and only the third time overall. But it's also significant for another reason.

With 18 caps to his name, Sarpreet is well placed to represent his nation at the quadrennial